



Caving News, 2011–2026

The life of cavingnews.com, the NSS's one-time media partner, told from public records only

Prepared by Aaron Bird, NSS #27029 (FE) • 9 October 2026

How this account was built, and what it leaves out

Board records

NSS minutes, agendas and officer reports, 2012–2023. Thirty pages mention the site, including the full text of the MOU.

The capture index

The Internet Archive's public index of 132,398 captures. Caving News article addresses carry their date, so the index alone gives the publication timeline.

Sixteen front pages

Archived copies of the public front page, 2011–2026: masthead, platform, section names, newest story shown.

Registry and About page

The .com registry's record for cavingnews.com, and the site's own public About page as served today.

Deliberately not read: any article page or reader comment. Caving News was a privately owned site; the only person named here is its owner, as named in NSS Board minutes as the MOU signatory. Every request was read-only, identified, rate-limited and logged.

Five things the record establishes

1

1,831 articles, 2011–2016

A one-person daily cave-news site. First article 12 March 2011, the day after the domain was registered; last article 21 April 2016.

2

An official NSS partner

MOU approved by the Board 31 March 2012 (Act 66-859), signed by the owner in June; NSS logo on the site, Caving News widget on caves.org and CaveChat.

3

Daily, then collapse, then a surge

35–45 articles a month to September 2013; near zero in 2014; 65–94 a month in the first half of 2015; then silence.

4

The NSS watched the feed

The widget 'went silent' in April 2015, the site's busiest month. 'Gone stale since April' 2016 is the real end. MOU rescinded 2023.

5

Dead 2021–2025, restored 2025

Every capture from Nov 2021 to Apr 2025 is a server error. Since August 2025 the original site answers again, unchanged, and is online today.



The daily years

March 2011 to September 2013: forty stories a month

Launched in March 2011 as a one-person daily

"Caving News was created by a caver/web developer with the goal of being the best source of daily cave news from around the world ... First launched in March 2011."

cavingnews.com/about, as served in October 2026

1,831

dated articles captured, 2011–2016

40

articles in a median month, 2011–2013



Sources: data/cavingnews_rdap.json; data/cavingnews_articles_by_month.csv; raw/cavingnews/20110813, 20120501; cavingnews.com/about

Caving News, 2011–2026 • public records only • compiled 2026-10-09

2012: the NSS signs a Memorandum of Understanding

"I noticed a website, CavingNews.com, some months ago and was impressed by its function. After consulting our IT department negotiations began with the site owner. We have worked out a MOU with CavingNews.com ... They will display our logo prominently at the top of their page along with their banner. We will post a widget on our homepage that will give a direct feed of 'Caving News' right on our home page ... daily news of the caving world!"

President's report, March 2012

The vote, 31 March 2012

Item 19, Shrewsbury moved: "The Memorandum of Understanding between the NSS and CavingNews.com is approved." Unanimous. Act 66-859, Appendix BA. Signed by the owner 10 June 2012.

What it promised

Mutual promotion and links; an NSS liaison to "assist Caving News in creating and providing ... news content"; each to "portray each other in a positive manner"; 30 days' notice to cancel.

● Jun 2012

Widget on caves.org home page and on CaveChat

● 2012

NSS supplies day-to-day convention coverage; "an extremely positive accomplishment"

● 2012-13

"This Week on CaveChat" column; Caving News called a "media partner"

● 23 Nov 2023

Act 66-859 rescinded in a batch: "a board act is not needed to justify an appendix"

Sources: PRES-1203.pdf p.3; 1203BOG.pdf pp.10, 15-16; OVP-1206 p.6, p.8; PRES-1206 p.15; PRES-1210 p.13; PRES-1303 p.16; 2311BOG.pdf p.4

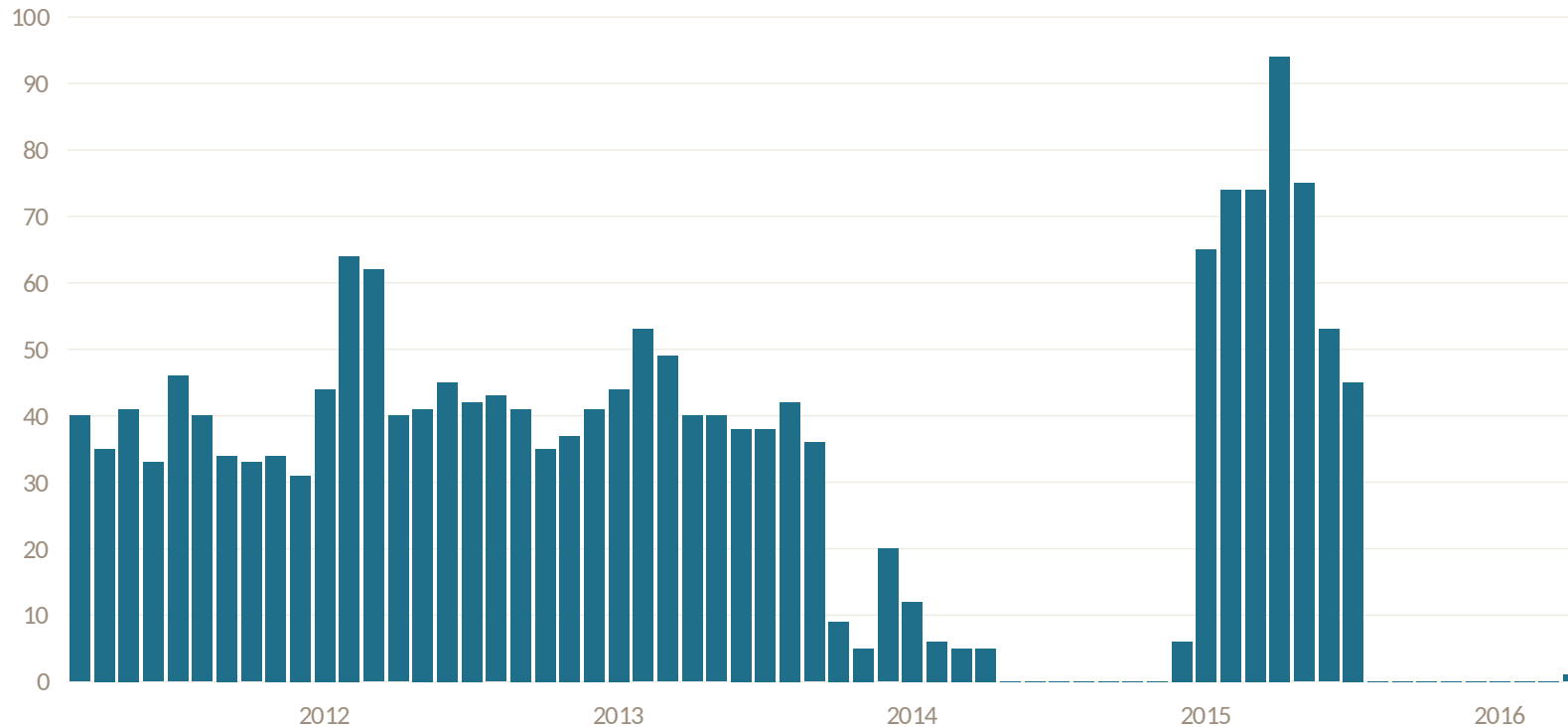


Collapse, revival, end

October 2013 to April 2016

Daily for 31 months, then a cliff, a surge, and silence

Dated articles per month, March 2011 – April 2016 (from article addresses in the capture index)



94

articles in April 2015, the busiest month

0

articles May–Nov 2014 and Aug 2015–Mar 2016

1

article in 2016: 21 April, the last

Source: [data/cavingnews_articles_by_month.csv](#). Counts are distinct article addresses with a 200 capture; uncaptured articles are not counted, so these are floors.

The NSS was watching the feed, not the site

What the Board was told

Mar 2015 *"The daily CavingNews widget went silent back in April. Email inquiries got no reply, so in early December, we reluctantly pulled the plug. Not two weeks later, it came back to life, so the widget has been reinstated."*

Oct 2016 *"This feature has gone stale since April, due to the owner's life hiccups; he is looking for help in maintaining this valuable service."*

Mar 2017 *"The CavingNews widget, which had died, has been removed."*

What the site was doing

Apr 2015 94 articles: the busiest month in the site's history. The widget ran on its own subdomain (widget.cavingnews.com); that is what failed, not publication.

Apr 2016 One article on 21 April, the last ever. The front page, software (WordPress 4.5) and newest story never change again.

2017-2021 Site online and unchanged; the NSS logo and link still on it. No hiatus or closure notice was ever posted.

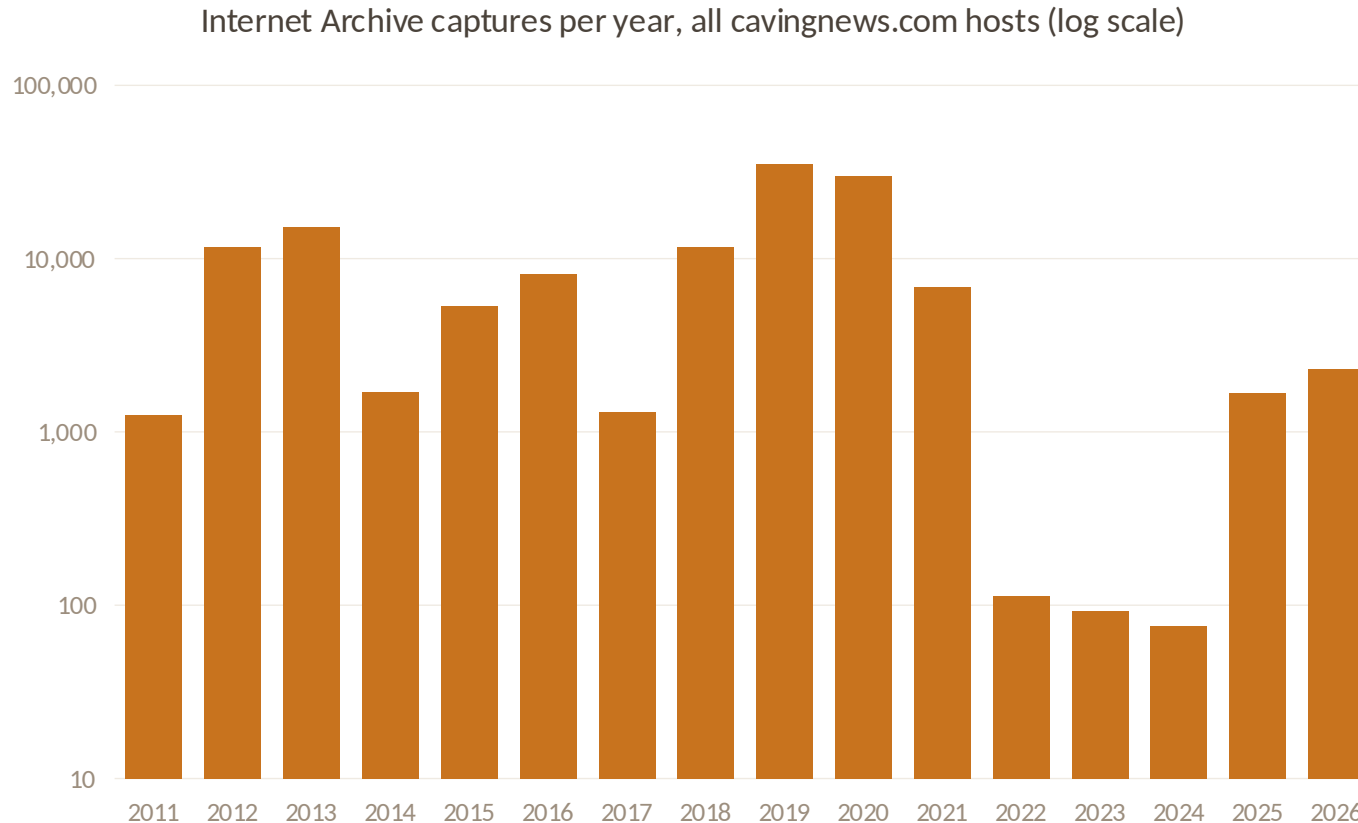
Sources: OVP-1503.pdf p.7; OVP-1610.pdf p.11; OVP-1703.pdf p.9; data/cavingnews_articles_by_month.csv; raw/cavingnews/ front pages 2016-2021; data/cavingnews_cdx.jsonl (widget. host)



Dead, then restored

November 2021 to today

Four years of server errors, then the same site comes back



● **29 Nov 2021**

First HTTP 500 on the front page. Every front-page and article capture until 15 April 2025 is an error.

● **23 Aug 2025**

Front page answers 200 again: 12 KB, WordPress 4.5, newest story 21 April 2016. 1,468 article captures succeed in 2025–26.

● **12 Mar 2026**

Registry record last changed; Cloudflare nameservers; registration runs to March 2027 (NameSilo).

● **9 Oct 2026**

Online today, serving its 2016 content, NSS logo and link included, with no notice of its status.

Sources: `data/cavingnews_cdx.jsonl`; `raw/cavingnews/20251015–20260711`; `data/cavingnews_rdap.json`; `cavingnews.com` (2026-10-09)

Caving News, 2011–2026 • public records only • compiled 2026-10-09

Two NSS channels, two endings

	CaveChat (NSS-owned forum)	Caving News (private partner)
Began	1 Sept 2005	12 Mar 2011
NSS instrument	Act 66-764, Nov 2005	MOU, Act 66-859, Mar 2012
Peak	~16,000 posts/yr, 2007–11	94 articles/month, Apr 2015
Last content	Dec 2024	21 Apr 2016
Instrument rescinded	Mar 2021	Nov 2023
Went dark	28 Mar 2025	29 Nov 2021
Today	Domain forwards to a dead host; moved to a new registrar Sept 2026	Restored Aug 2025; online, unchanged since 2016
Public archive	Internet Archive crawl, 3–4 Jan 2021	The site itself, plus the Archive

Sources: docs/research/2026-10-09_cavechat-history_findings.md; this account

Caving News, 2011–2026 • public records only • compiled 2026-10-09



Year by year

Eleven articles, 2011–2016, as the site published them

How these eleven were chosen, and how they were captured

Chosen from 1,831 addresses

Two articles a year for 2011–2015 and the single article of 2016, picked from the article addresses in the capture index for one of three reasons: a milestone in the site's own life, the NSS relationship in action, or a landmark in caving that the site covered as news. Headlines are the site's own.

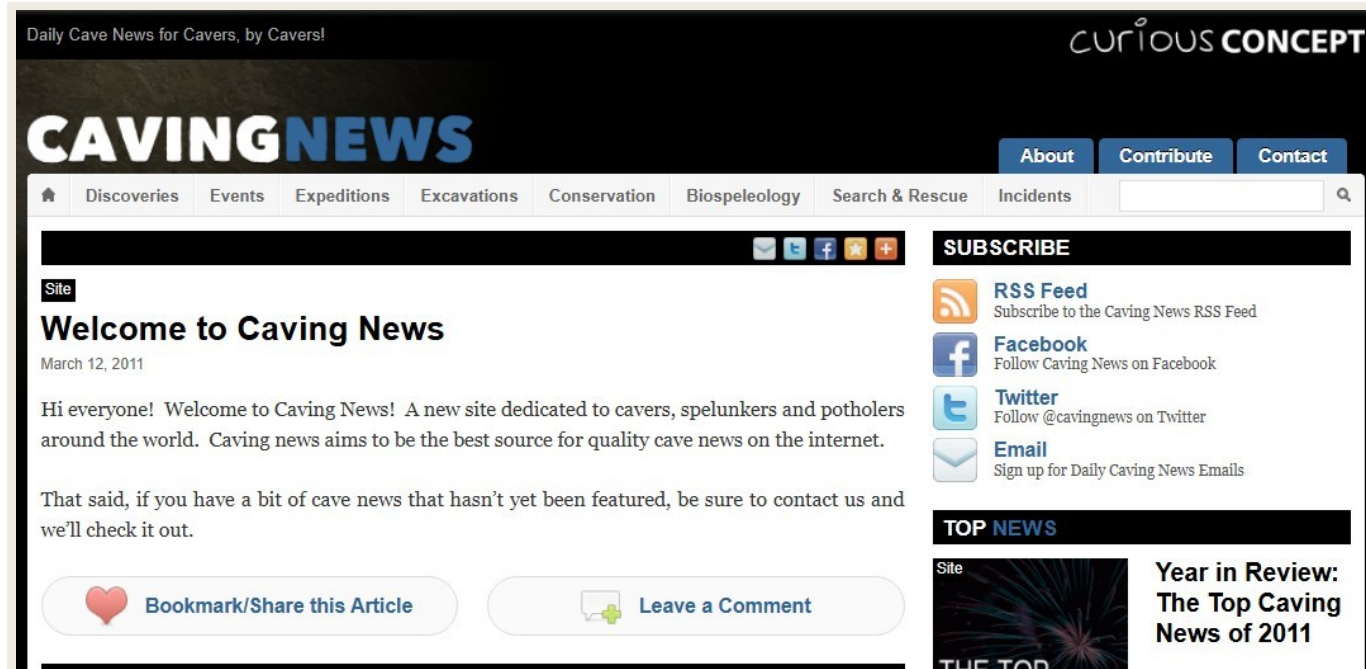
Captured by hand

The live site was intermittently reachable on 9 October 2026 (Cloudflare 521 at the time of capture). Each article was opened in the Wayback Machine in a browser on Aaron's computer, at its earliest successful capture, and screenshotted. Three captures were archived without their stylesheet and appear as bare text.

What is and is not here

Articles are published journalism on an open website and are quoted as such. Reader comments were not read. Guest authors and commenters are referred to by role, never by name; the site's owner is named only as its publisher, as the NSS Board minutes name him. The full screenshots, including sidebars, are in `raw/cavingnews/screenshots/`; the slides show the article area.

2011: Welcome to Caving News



Wayback capture 7 Jan 2012

12 March 2011

Welcome to Caving News

The founding post

“Hi everyone! Welcome to Caving News! A new site dedicated to cavers, spelunkers and potholers around the world.” Three sentences and an invitation to send in news. The masthead says “Daily Cave News for Cavers, by Cavers!”; the Curious Concept mark is the developer’s own studio. By January 2012 the site had already published a year-in-review and posts about its own milestones.

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2011-03-12_welcome-to-caving-news_*; capture 7 Jan 2012

2011: WNS at the NSS Convention



25 July 2011

Cavers Discuss White-Nose Syndrome at NSS Convention

WNS and the NSS: the site's defining beat

The Glenwood Springs session "White Nose Syndrome — A Western Perspective": the NSS liaison calls evidence of human spread "speculation and hypotheses"; the Fish and Wildlife Service says there is "strong evidence" the fungus can be carried by people. Then the site's own line: closures "are only effective at keeping the responsible cavers out."

Wayback capture 6 Jan 2012

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2011-07-25_cavers-discuss-wns-at-nss-convention_*; capture 6 Jan 2012

2012: Up to 6.7 Million Bats Killed by WNS

[Biospeleology Conservation](#)

New Estimate: Up to 6.7 Million Bats Killed by WNS

January 20, 2012 / [Canada](#), [United States](#), [North America](#)



Photo by 9brandon/flickr

Earlier this week the [U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service](#) announced that their biologists now estimate that at least 5.7 million to 6.7 million bats have now died from [white-nose synd](#). Estimating the total number of bats that succumbed to the disease has been a difficult task for researchers because population counts for of the many common bat species, such as the little brown bat, are difficult. This lack of information led to the commonly heard estimate of “more than a million” dead bats that has been restated thousands of times since 2009.

Last week, during a the 2012 [Northeast Bat Working Group](#) (NEBWG) meeting last week in Carlisle, Pennsylvania, more than 140 government biologists and bat researchers v. white nose syndrome has claimed.

In order to improve future estimates, one of the goals from the [U.S. national WNS response plan](#), which was developed last May 2011 by the Fish and Wildlife Service, was to [North American bat death toll exceeds 5.5 million from white-nose syndrome](#) [U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service via [NSS White Nose Syndrome Page](#)]

Wayback capture 24 Jan 2012 (archived without its stylesheet)

20 January 2012

New Estimate: Up to 6.7 Million Bats Killed by WNS

The WNS story at its peak, sourced via the NSS

USFWS biologists now estimate 5.7 to 6.7 million bats dead since 2006, replacing the “more than a million” figure “restated thousands of times since 2009.” The source line reads “U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service via NSS White Nose Syndrome Page”: NSS material feeding the site two months before the MOU.

Source: [raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2012-01-20.jpg_*](#); capture 24 Jan 2012 (archived without its stylesheet)

2012: Caving News Joins Forces with the NSS

Caving News Joins Forces with National Speleological Society

March 12, 2012



On the first birthday of Caving News, we are happy to announce that we have joined forces with the [National Speleological Society](#).

We have partnered together to further our mutual goals, to introduce more people around the world to interesting news about caves and caving, as well as to increase the

We hope that this partnership will also increase the quality and quantity of caving news that we cover, including bringing on new content writers.

The Widget

As part of the alliance, we have developed a brand new [Caving News Widget](#) to be featured on the [NSS website](#). What's extra exciting is that the widget is not restricted

Head on over to the [widget page](#) to customize and grab the code.

Thanks for all the support.

[Site](#)

12 March 2012

Caving News Joins Forces with National Speleological Society

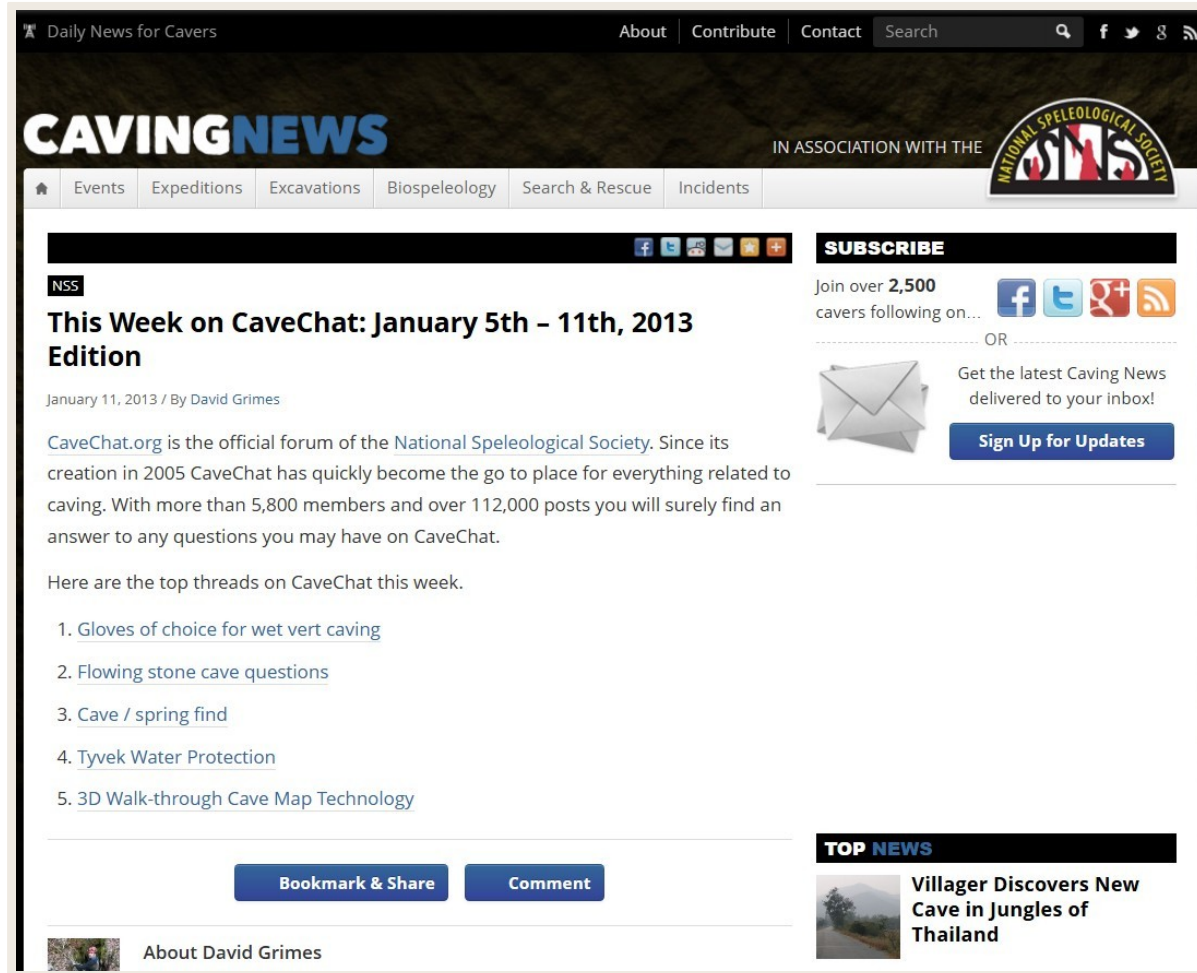
The MOU, from the site's side

"On the first birthday of Caving News, we are happy to announce that we have joined forces with the National Speleological Society." Goals: more readers for both, "bringing on new content writers," and a Caving News Widget "to be featured on the NSS website" and free for anyone's site. The Board approved the MOU nineteen days later; the owner signed in June.

Wayback capture 14 Mar 2012 (archived without its stylesheet)

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2012-03-12_caving-news-joins-forces-with-nss_*.capture 14 Mar 2012 (archived without its stylesheet)

2013: This Week on CaveChat



11 January 2013

This Week on CaveChat: January 5th–11th, 2013 Edition

The forum column: the two histories meet

The masthead now reads “IN ASSOCIATION WITH THE” NSS seal and the column is tagged NSS. Its standing intro: CaveChat, “the official forum of the National Speleological Society ... more than 5,800 members and over 112,000 posts,” figures that match the forum’s own counters. Five thread titles follow; the author box describes the forum administrator’s role in his own words.

Wayback capture 15 Jan 2013

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2013-01-11_this-week-on-cavechat_*; capture 15 Jan 2013

2013: Mammoth Cave Hits 400 Miles

16 February 2013

Kentucky's Mammoth Cave Hits 400 Miles

A landmark, reported at full stride

Announced at the Mammoth Cave Research Symposium by the park superintendent and the Cave Research Foundation president: 400 miles, 643 km, “incremental additions ... rather than a single major discovery,” and 10,669 CRF volunteer hours in 2012. Properly sourced, NPS photo, 2,700 followers in the sidebar.

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Kentucky's Mammoth Cave Hits 400 Miles

February 16, 2013 / Kentucky, United States, North America

Kentucky's Mammoth Cave, the longest cave in the world, has now been surveyed to an amazing 400 miles (643 kilometers).

The announcement was made by [Mammoth Cave National Park](#) Superintendent Sarah Craighead and [Cave Research Foundation](#) President Charles Fox during [Friday's Mammoth Cave Research Symposium](#).



Dismal Hollow in Mammoth Cave. Photo by NPS

“ The expansion of the Mammoth Cave system in the last few years has been a matter of incremental additions to many parts of the cave rather than a single major discovery that pushed the cave past 400 miles. In recent years we have resurveyed sections of the cave so that we can produce more detailed maps that meet modern mapping standards, as well as exploring and mapping previously unexplored passages. — Charles Fox, Cave Research Foundation President ”

The milestone was reached thanks to a cooperative effort between the National Park

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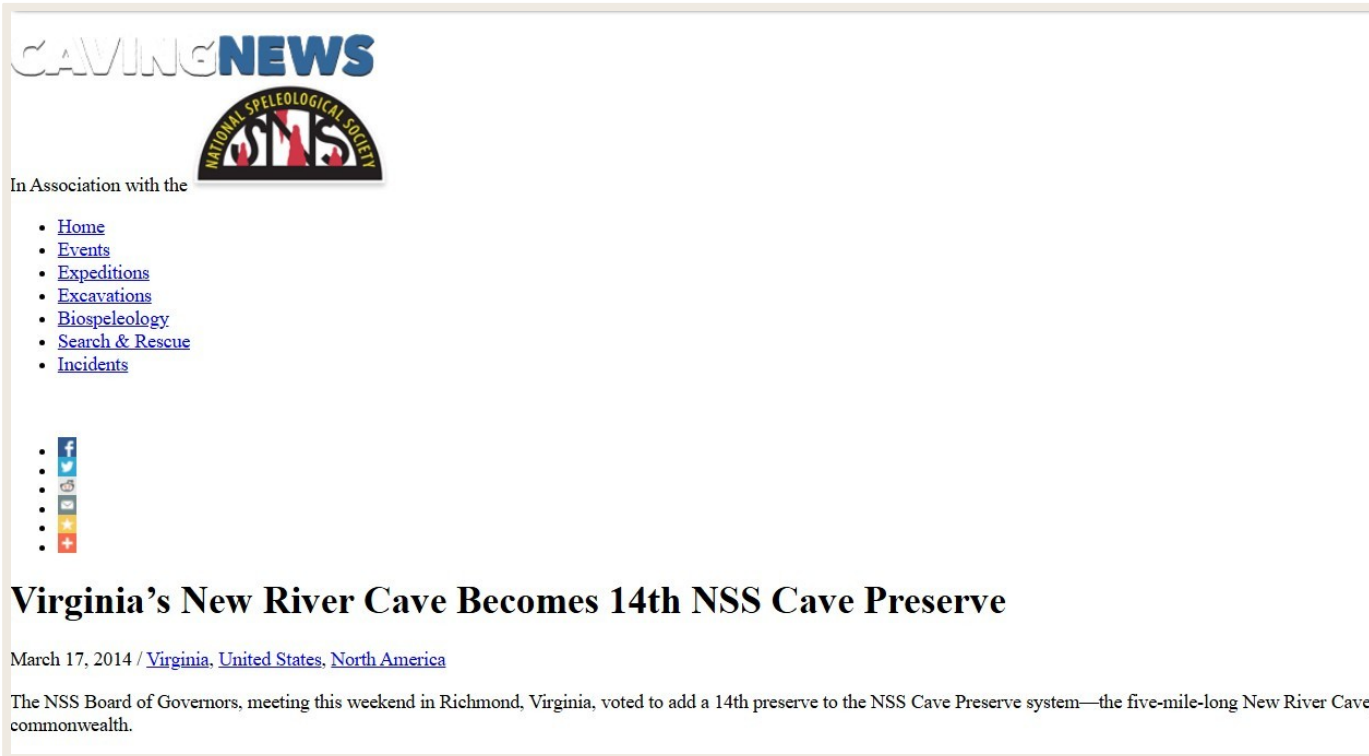
TOP NEWS

 **Kentucky's Mammoth Cave Hits 400 Miles**

Wayback capture 22 Feb 2013

Source: [raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2013-02-16_mammoth-cave-hits-400-miles_*](#); capture 22 Feb 2013

2014: New River Cave, 14th NSS Preserve



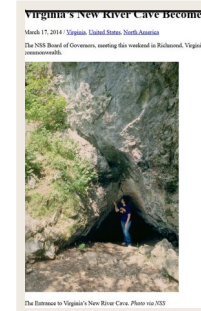
Wayback capture 17 Mar 2014 (archived without its stylesheet)

17 March 2014

Virginia's New River Cave Becomes 14th NSS Cave Preserve

Board news within days, in the thin year

"The NSS Board of Governors, meeting this weekend in Richmond, Virginia, voted to add a 14th preserve ... the five-mile-long New River Cave, longest cave in Giles County ... the first cave preserve for the society in the commonwealth." Photo "via NSS." Published the weekend of the vote, in a month with five articles: the MOU's liaison clause in practice.



Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2014-03-17_new-river-cave-14th-nss-preserve_*.capture 17 Mar 2014 (archived without its stylesheet)

2014: Save Son Doong



1 December 2014

Real Explorers Don't Use Cable Cars: Save Son Doong

A guest essay: advocacy on the eve of the revival

A long first-person piece by a Vietnam Caves Project expedition caver: why he caves, the 255-metre entrance pitch of Vuc Tang in 2007, Hang En and Son Doong, and the case against the proposed cable car, ending with the #SaveSonDoong petition. The 2015 navigation (Science, Conservation, Exploration ...) is already in place; 4,300 followers. The site reported the outcome in February 2015: no development until 2030.

Wayback capture 8 Dec 2014

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2014-12-01_save-son-doong_*; capture 8 Dec 2014

2015: Welcome to the 2015 NSS Convention



Wayback capture 2 Feb 2015 (the only capture)

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2015-01-23_missouri-mayor-welcomes-2015-nss-convention_*; capture 2 Feb 2015 (the only capture)

23 January 2015

Missouri Mayor Welcomes Cavers to the 2015 NSS Convention

The revival: NSS content, 4,500 followers

The Waynesville mayor's first official release: 2,000 cavers expected, "over 6,300 caves" in Missouri, Roubidoux Spring, 13–17 July. The ticker still says "Get the Caving News Widget!" and the related strip is a small history of NSS conventions as the site covered them: Glenwood Springs 2011, Shippensburg 2013, Ely 2016 announced.

2015: Jewel Cave Surpasses 175 Miles



Wayback capture 23 Feb 2015

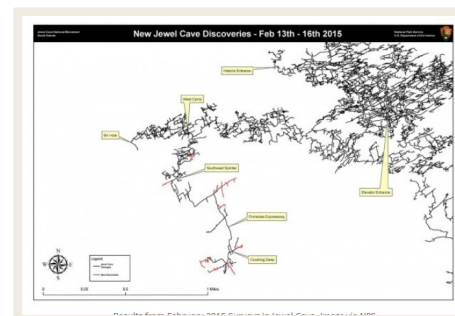
Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2015-02-21_jewel-cave-surpasses-175-miles_*; capture 23 Feb 2015

21 February 2015

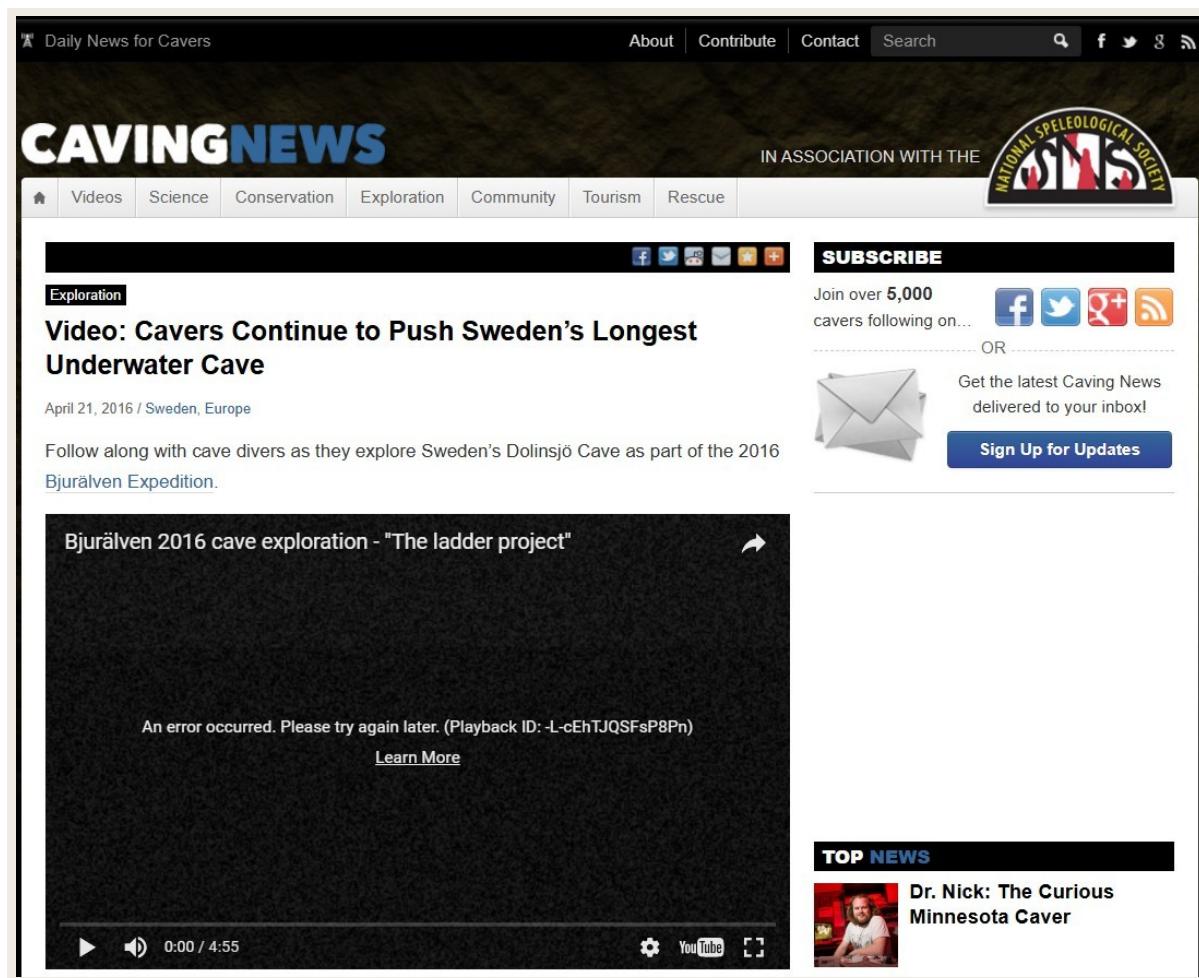
Jewel Cave Surpasses 175 Miles in Length

Survey news, with the line plot

Two teams at West Camp over Valentine's weekend: 6,557.65 ft surveyed, 175.13 miles total, depth to 677 ft, "over 100 unexplored leads." Third longest behind Mammoth and Sac Actun. The NPS line plot, new passage in red, runs with the story. 4,600 followers: the site's busiest season.



2016: The last article: Bjurälven, Sweden

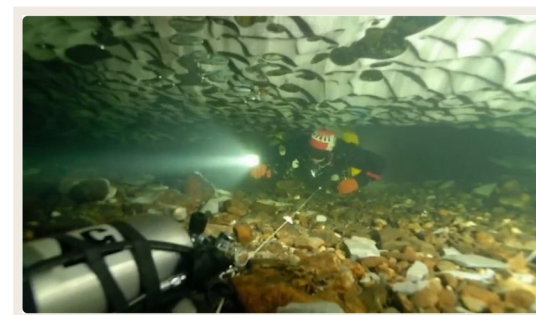


21 April 2016

Video: Cavers Continue to Push Sweden's Longest Underwater Cave

The last article

Four lines around a video from the 2016 Bjurälven expedition: a folding aluminium ladder to reach the roof of "the rain hall"; Dolinsjö Cave extended 353 m to 2,135 m. 5,000 followers; the widget banner still running. Nothing on the page suggests an ending, and this story has been the newest on every front page since, through October 2026.



Frame from the Bjurälven expedition's video

Wayback capture 21 Apr 2016, the same day

Source: raw/cavingnews/screenshots/2016-04-21_swedens-longest-underwater-cave_*; capture 21 Apr 2016, the same day

What the eleven show together

The site's arc, in its masthead

"Daily Cave News for Cavers, by Cavers!" with the studio mark (2011); "IN ASSOCIATION WITH THE" NSS seal from 2012 to the end. Followers: 2,500 (Jan 2013) → 2,700 → 4,300 → 4,500 → 4,600 → 5,000 (Apr 2016), still rising after publication stopped.

The NSS relationship was content

WNS material "via NSS" before the MOU; the CaveChat column and NSS News previews through the thin months; Board decisions and convention releases reported within days. The logo was the visible part of a working arrangement.

White-nose syndrome is the thread

From the first year's convention session and the 6.7-million estimate to the last front page ("Idaho Fish and Game enlists cavers in WNS battle", April 2016), WNS is the story the site returned to most.

Three kinds of piece

Aggregated news with a source line (most of the 1,831); the site's own editorial voice, as in the 2011 passage on cave closures; and guest essays, as in the 2014 Son Doong piece. The mix is what the MOU's "new content writers" hoped for.

What the public record does not say

Why it stopped

Why publication collapsed in October 2013 and ended in July 2015. The Board's 2016 report says only "the owner's life hiccups."

The liaison

The MOU created an NSS Caving News liaison. No public document names one, or records the MOU being cancelled before 2023.

The restoration

What failed in November 2021, who brought the site back in August 2025, and who renewed the domain in March 2026.

Its future

Whether the restored site is meant as a permanent archive of 1,831 articles, and whether the NSS link on it still reflects a relationship.

Method, limits and where to check

What was requested

A few index queries to the Internet Archive's public CDX API; 16 archived front pages; one registry (RDAP) lookup; the site's public About page, once.

How

The same read-only client as the Board-minutes archive: GET/HEAD only, identified by name and contact, 1 request per 2 s to the Archive, robots.txt honored, no cookies, every request logged.

What was not done

No article page or reader comment was read. No byline other than the owner's, as named in Board minutes, is recorded.

Known limits

Monthly counts are distinct dated article addresses with a successful capture, so they are floors; for 2011–2013, with daily crawling, they are close to complete. Registrant data is redacted by design.



Five years, 1,831 stories, one caver

The NSS's daily news partner, 2011–2016, still online in 2026 with the Society's logo on its masthead.